

ENG 439: Literature and Censorship 2025 – 26 (II)

First Course Handout

Schedule: 11:00 - 11:50 am W Th F

Venue: L 14

About the Course

Freedom of expression is a fundamental right that is being discussed all over the world today. This course is an exploration of this right to free expression in the context of literature. We will try to understand what constitutes censorship – whether it is a weapon used by a country against dissidents or an inner voice that tells you to avoid certain issues that might lead to unnecessary conflict and confrontations. The course will also analyze texts that have faced problems and have had to be withdrawn from a syllabus or the bookshelves.

The course is structured around two broad divisions; Section I will explore the concept of censorship and the various ways in which literature is restricted. This will consist of a mix of fiction and non-fiction, while the second section will focus on texts that have been banned.

Section I: On Censorship

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| 1. On Censorship (essay): | Salman Rushdie |
| 2. Enemies of Free Speech (essay): | Kenan Malik |
| 3. No Offence Intended (story): | Kaya Genç |
| 4. John and Mary (short story): | Margaret Atwood |
| 5. 1984 (Excerpt from the novel): | George Orwell |
| 6. Story of a Poem (short story): | Chandrika Balan |
| 7. Anti Ha (short story): | Shalom Auslander |
| 8. Rhinoceros (play): | Eugene Ionesco |
| 9. The Tree of Tongues (poem): | K Satchidanandan |

Section II: Censored

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| 1. Bu (short story): | Saadat Hasan Manto |
| 2. The Lottery (short story): | Shirley Jackson |
| 3. Lamb to the Slaughter: | Roald Dahl |
| 4. Emergency (poem): | Phanishwar Nath Renu |
| 5. One part Woman (excerpts from the novel): | Perumal Murugan |
| 6. Eating with the Enemy (short story): | Hansda Sowvendra Sekhar |
| 7. Draupadi (short story): | Mahasweta Devi |
| 8. The Hill we Climb (poem): | Amanda Gorman |

9. We shall See (poem):

Faiz Ahmad Faiz

There might be alterations to the syllabus – texts might be dropped if there is lack of time to cover all of them. The texts, other than the novels and plays, will be uploaded on the Hello IITK page.

Course Policy

You are expected to attend classes regularly and participate in class discussions. Regular attendance will also help in getting better grades, as the exams will be based on the discussions in class.

Please reach the classroom within 15 minutes of the bell, to avoid disturbance to the others in class.

Make-up for quizzes or exams will be given only on medical grounds or other compelling reasons. You should be able to produce documents to support your case, medical or otherwise.

There will be four quizzes in class, each worth 10%. Two will be before the mid-sem and two after. Quizzes will be announced beforehand.

Please send me an email to fix an appointment. You are welcome to have more discussions with me, or contact me if you have any questions or concerns.

Grades and weightage

Quiz: 40%

Mid-sem: 20%

End-sem: 35%

Attendance: 5%

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